

PRODUCT STRATEGY & COMPETITIVE BRIEF

Restaurant Ordering & Billing Software

Market landscape, competitor plans, and a build-ready feature roadmap

What this covers: order taking → kitchen routing via thermal printer (KOT) → GST bill + UPI QR for instant payment.

Market focus: Indian restaurant POS, with a lens on Tier 2/3 cities (Kalyan, Thane, Nashik).

Audience: founder + developer. The final section is written to hand straight to your dev.

Prepared June 2026 · Pricing figures are public-source estimates; vendors hide most rates behind "Contact Sales", so treat ranges as directional.

01 The opportunity in one page

The Indian restaurant POS market is large, crowded, and quietly frustrated. There is a clear wedge for a transparent, automation-led product aimed at smaller outlets in Tier 2/3 cities.

What's actually happening in the market

- **The incumbents win on integration, not love.** Petpooja (1,00,000+ outlets) and Restroworks/POSist dominate, but reviews repeatedly flag dated UI, slow night-time support, and core features locked behind paid add-ons.
- **Pricing is deliberately opaque.** Most players hide rates behind a "Contact Sales" button, then bundle hardware and annual lock-ins. Real all-in cost for a single outlet lands around **₹15,000–30,000/year**, and ₹5,000–12,000/month once add-ons stack up.
- **Hardware lock-in is the biggest grievance.** Vendors sell ₹15,000–25,000 proprietary terminals that run software a ₹8,000 Android tablet handles fine. New entrants are attacking exactly this.
- **A price-disruption wave has started.** Browser-based newcomers (BillFeeds ₹999/mo, DineOpen ₹300/mo) bundle KDS, QR ordering and "no hardware, no lock-in" as standard.
- **AI + messaging is the 2026 frontier.** WhatsApp ordering now captures 15–30% of orders for D2C restaurants; AI voice agents take phone orders at ₹5–25/order vs ₹35–85 for a human. Legacy players are slow here.

Your unfair advantage: you already build a **WhatsApp automation tool** and an **AI calling agent**, and you already do in-person walk-in sales to Tier 2/3 businesses. Every major POS sells WhatsApp ordering and AI voice as premium add-ons — or doesn't have them. Bundling them into an honestly-priced, no-hardware-lock-in POS is a genuinely differentiated wedge in Kalyan/Thane/Nashik, where the big players have thin ground support.

The strategic read

Don't try to out-feature Petpooja on day one. Win on the four things a small restaurant truly needs — **take an order, send it to the kitchen, print a GST bill, collect payment fast** — delivered with transparent pricing, zero hardware lock-in, and your automation stack baked in. Use feature depth (inventory, multi-outlet, aggregators) to retain and upsell, not to acquire.

02 Competitor landscape at a glance

The players you'll be measured against, grouped by who they're built for. Pricing is per outlet unless noted.

Player	Tier / fit	Indicative pricing	Known for	Where it's weak
Petpooja	Mid-large, single to chains. Market leader.	Not public. ~₹15k–30k/yr realistic all-in; ₹5k–12k/mo with add-ons. Hardware bundled.	Best-in-class Zomato/Swiggy sync, 200+ printer support, 200+ integrations, ground presence in 200+ cities, 24×7 support.	Dated/cluttered UI, slow night support, loyalty & analytics are paid add-ons, no AI features, annual contracts.
Restroworks (POSist)	Enterprise & chains (10+ outlets).	~₹1,500–3,000+/mo per outlet; custom enterprise quotes (~\$200/mo+).	Multi-location dashboards, supply chain, strong analytics, central CRM, browser-based + offline mode.	Overkill & overpriced for a single small outlet; training-heavy onboarding.
DotPe / Rista	Digital-first, QSR, cloud kitchens.	Rista Basic ~\$139, Premium ~\$278 per store/yr; enterprise bundles quoted ~₹1,00,000.	QR-based table ordering, direct-ordering channel to cut aggregator commission, digital payments, marketing tools, mobile-first.	QR flow leans on customer internet; weaker for traditional dine-in-only setups.
TMBill	SMB restaurants, 14,000+ outlets, dealer-led.	From ~₹5,999 (entry, via resellers).	QR ordering, BharatPe auto-settlement, aggregator sync, 24×7 support, affordable, strong dealer network.	KOT reprint friction on running-order edits; mixed after-sales reviews.
SlickPOS	Very small outlets, stalls, food trucks.	Free tier + paid (~₹1,500–4,000/mo equiv).	Genuinely easy to use, real free plan, SMS digital receipts, waiter app.	Thin free plan (no inventory/QR/KOT), reliability complaints (missing bills), waiter app sold separately.
Disruptors (BillFeeds, DineOpen, LithosPOS)	Price-sensitive small outlets — <i>your zone</i> .	₹300–999/mo, everything included, no hardware, no lock-in.	Transparent flat pricing, browser-based, KDS + QR included, AI voice ordering (DineOpen), zero transaction fees.	Smaller integration catalogues, thin ground support, limited enterprise/franchise depth.

Reading the table: the top three compete on *depth and integrations*; the bottom three compete on *price and simplicity*. The under-served middle is a **simple, honestly-priced product with serious automation (WhatsApp + AI voice) and real local support** — which is precisely the gap your existing products and GTM fit.

03 Competitor deep-dives

Same structure for each: who it's for, what its plans look like, and the strengths/weaknesses that matter when you're selling against it.

Petpooja — the default everyone compares to

1,00,000+ outlets · since 2011 · India, UAE, Middle East, Canada, South Africa

Plans: No public pricing — quote-based, typically annual contracts with hardware bundled. Owners report ₹15,000–30,000/year for a single outlet, rising fast once inventory, CRM, loyalty or online-ordering modules are added. Supports 200+ printer types (WiFi/LAN/USB/Bluetooth/dot-matrix/thermal) and 200+ third-party integrations.

Strengths

- Mature, reliable Zomato/Swiggy order ingestion
- Huge integration catalogue + Tally/GST automation
- On-ground technicians in 200+ cities, 24×7 support
- Handles complex multi-cuisine menus and chains well

Weaknesses to exploit

- UI feels dated and cluttered; longer staff training
- Loyalty, advanced analytics, WhatsApp ordering = paid add-ons
- No AI/voice features
- Opaque pricing + lock-in frustrates small owners

Restroworks / POSist — the enterprise option

15,000+ restaurants · founded 2011, Delhi

Plans: ~₹1,500–3,000+/month per location; custom enterprise quotes. Positioned for mid-to-large chains and multi-country operators.

Strengths

- Strong multi-location & franchise management
- Deep analytics, supply chain, central CRM
- Browser-based, runs on any hardware, offline mode
- 150+ integrations incl. KDS & online ordering

Weaknesses to exploit

- Priced and built for chains — wrong fit for a single small outlet
- Configuration/onboarding is heavy
- Reported lag and report-download friction

DotPe / Rista — the QR & direct-ordering specialist

QR-ordering origin, expanded into full POS via Rista

Plans: Rista Basic ~\$139 and Premium ~\$278 per store/year; larger setups quoted around ₹1,00,000. Core pitch is building a restaurant's own ordering channel to dodge aggregator commissions.

Strengths

- Best-in-class QR scan-to-order at the table
- Integrated digital payments & marketing tools
- Mobile-first, runs on all hardware, offline capable
- Direct ordering reduces 20–25% aggregator commission

Weaknesses to exploit

- QR ordering depends on customer's own internet
- Less natural for traditional captain-led dine-in

TMBill — the affordable, dealer-driven SMB play

14,000+ brands · 350+ cities · reseller network

Plans: entry from ~₹5,999 via dealers. Bundles QR ordering, CRM, loyalty, aggregator sync, inventory, recipe/wastage management.

Strengths

- Affordable, broad feature set for the price
- BharatPe auto-settlement integration
- Strong reseller/dealer distribution + 24×7 support

Weaknesses to exploit

- Must reprint KOT for running-order edits (operational friction)
- Inconsistent after-sales experience in reviews

SlickPOS & the disruptors — your direct price-tier rivals

SlickPOS (free tier) · BillFeeds (₹999/mo) · DineOpen (₹300/mo) · LithosPOS

Plans: SlickPOS has a real free tier but gates inventory/QR/KOT behind paid plans. BillFeeds bundles KDS + QR table ordering + multi-branch from ₹999/mo with no lock-in. DineOpen leads on AI — voice ordering in Hindi/Marathi/Tamil, AI menu extraction, zero transaction fees, from ₹300/mo.

What they get right

- Transparent flat pricing, no "Contact Sales"
- Browser/Android-based — no proprietary hardware
- Everything-included plans; AI as a headline feature

Where you can still beat them

- Thin local/on-ground support — you can win on physical presence
- Generic WhatsApp; your automation tool is purpose-built
- Limited enterprise depth as clients grow

04 Gaps to exploit & your positioning

Where the market consistently underdelivers — and how your specific assets map onto each gap.

Market gap	Why it exists	Your move
Opaque pricing	Vendors hide rates to enable per-deal upselling and hardware bundling.	Publish flat, all-inclusive monthly pricing on your site. Make transparency the headline.
Hardware lock-in	Proprietary ₹15–25k terminals are a margin centre.	Run in a browser / cheap Android tablet. "Use the hardware you already own."
Add-on creep	KDS, loyalty, WhatsApp gated to inflate ARPU.	Bundle the essentials. Charge only for genuinely advanced/multi-outlet tiers.
Weak automation	WhatsApp ordering & AI voice are bolt-ons or absent.	Ship your WhatsApp automation + AI calling agent as native, not add-ons.
Thin Tier 2/3 support	Big players concentrate field staff in metros.	Your walk-in GTM in Kalyan/Thane/ Nashik = same-day, in-person setup & support.

A one-line positioning to test

"The honest restaurant POS for Maharashtra's growing towns — order to kitchen to UPI in seconds, with WhatsApp & AI phone ordering built in, on the device you already own. No hidden costs. Set up by someone who'll actually show up."

A pricing model that fits the gap

Mirror the transparent-tier disruptors but anchor your premium tier on automation (your moat). Illustrative, to validate against your cost floor:

Tier	Indicative price	Who it's for	Core inclusions
Starter	~₹499/mo	Stalls, single small outlet	Orders, KOT printing, GST bill, UPI QR, daily sales report
Growth	~₹999–1,499/mo	Standard dine-in restaurant	Starter + QR menu, KDS, inventory, CRM, WhatsApp bill/ordering
Automate	~₹2,499–3,999/mo	Busy outlets / small chains	Growth + AI phone-order agent, aggregator sync, multi-outlet, loyalty

Keep your 40% minimum-margin discipline (as with your AI calling agent) when costing the Automate tier — voice minutes and WhatsApp conversation fees are real variable costs to price in.

05 Feature plan for the developer

Phased so you can ship something sellable fast, then layer depth. Each item notes what it is and the key technical consideration. Build the MVP completely before touching V1.

Phase 1 — MVP (the 4 things a restaurant must have)

Goal: a single outlet can take an order, fire it to the kitchen, print a GST bill, and get paid by UPI. Target: 6–8 weeks.

Order taking

- **MVP Menu management** — items, categories, variations (half/full), add-ons, and a *per-item GST rate* (5%/12%/18%). This is the foundation; model it cleanly.
- **MVP Fast order screen** — large tap targets, three order types: dine-in (with table), takeaway, delivery. Edit/add items to a running order before billing.
- **MVP Table map** — simple grid of tables with occupied/free status; merge/split/move tables.

Kitchen routing (KOT via thermal printer)

- **MVP KOT generation & printing** — on order-confirm, print a kitchen ticket. *Tech:* use the **ESC/POS** command set, the universal thermal-printer standard. Support 58mm and 80mm rolls. Connect over **USB, Bluetooth, LAN/WiFi (port 9100 raw)**. On Android, the simplest reliable path is an ESC/POS library + Bluetooth/network printer; for web, a small local print-bridge or a desktop helper that exposes the printer.
- **MVP Multi-station routing** — route items to the right printer (e.g. drinks → bar printer, food → kitchen). Even if you start with one printer, design the routing rule now.
- **MVP Edit-and-reprint logic** — handle added/cancelled items on a running order gracefully (print only the delta, clearly marked). TMBill is criticised for forcing a full reprint — beat them on this.

Billing & payment

- **MVP GST-compliant bill** — itemised, CGST/SGST split, discounts, service charge, rounding. Sequential invoice numbering. Print to thermal + share as PDF.
- **MVP Dynamic UPI QR with amount** — generate a UPI QR pre-filled with the bill amount so the customer scans and pays instantly. *Tech:* build a UPI deep-link string (`upi://pay?pa=<vpa>&pn=<name>&am=<amount>&tn=<invoice>&cu=INR`) and render it to a QR. For automatic payment *confirmation* (not just display), integrate a PG dynamic-QR API (Razorpay/Cashfree/PhonePe) so the bill auto-marks paid on webhook — this is a real differentiator over a static QR.
- **MVP Payment modes** — cash, UPI, card; split payment; mark settled.

Foundation (non-negotiable for India)

- **MVP Offline-first billing** — bill and print even when internet drops, then sync to cloud. This is repeatedly cited as critical; build local cache + sync queue from day one, not later.
- **MVP Roles & access** — cashier / manager / owner. Owner sees reports; cashier can't void without approval.
- **MVP Daily sales report** — day-end total, order count, payment-mode split, top items.

Phase 2 — V1 (competitive parity + your moat)

Goal: match what mid-tier players offer, and switch on the automation that makes you different.

- **V1 KDS (Kitchen Display Screen)** — a screen alternative to paper KOT (cheap tablet on the wall); order ageing, bump-to-done. Sell as a "no extra printer" option.
- **V1 QR menu / scan-to-order** — customer scans table QR, browses menu, places order straight into the POS. This is DotPe's core strength — match it.

- **V1 WhatsApp bill share + ordering** — send the bill on WhatsApp; let customers order via WhatsApp. *This is where your existing WhatsApp automation tool plugs in directly.*
- **V1 Inventory + recipe-level deduction** — selling one biryani deducts rice/chicken/spices. Low-stock alerts. Big retention driver.
- **V1 CRM + loyalty** — customer phone, order history, points/offers. Most players charge extra; bundle it in Growth.
- **V1 Aggregator integration** — Zomato/Swiggy menu sync + order ingestion into one screen. Hardest to build well; prioritise menu sync first.
- **V1 Multi-outlet dashboard** — consolidated view once a client opens a second location.

Phase 3 — V2 (differentiation that's hard to copy)

Goal: the features that turn you from "another cheap POS" into a category of one in your region.

- **V2 AI phone-order agent** — customer calls, your AI agent takes the order in Hindi/Marathi/English and fires the KOT directly. *This is your existing AI calling agent repurposed* — roughly ₹5–25/order vs ₹35–85 for human phone staff. Headline feature for the Automate tier.
- **V2 AI menu extraction** — photograph a paper/PDF menu, auto-digitise into items + prices. Removes the biggest onboarding chore and shortens your walk-in sales cycle.
- **V2 Direct online-ordering site** — branded ordering page so the restaurant takes orders commission-free (vs 20–25% aggregator cut).
- **V2 Captain/waiter app** — staff take orders tableside on a phone; flows straight to KDS/KOT.
- **V2 Predictive inventory** — forecast stock needs from sales history; reduce wastage.

Suggested tech notes to hand your dev

- **Architecture:** cloud backend + offline-capable client. A Progressive Web App or Android app both work; Android gives the most reliable Bluetooth/USB thermal printing for Tier 2/3 setups.
- **Printing:** standardise on ESC/POS; keep a tested printer profile list (58mm/80mm, common brands like Epson/TVS/Everycom). Don't hardcode one model.
- **Payments:** start with a static-amount UPI QR (zero integration cost) for MVP, then add a PG dynamic-QR webhook for auto-reconciliation in V1.
- **Compliance:** GST invoice format, sequential numbering, and e-invoicing only kicks in above the turnover threshold — flag but don't over-build early.
- **Data model first:** menu, order, KOT, bill, payment, and the sync queue are the spine. Get these right before UI polish.

Build sequence in one line: Menu → Order screen → KOT print (ESC/POS) → GST bill → UPI QR → offline sync → (*ship & sell*) → KDS + QR menu + WhatsApp → inventory/CRM/aggregators → AI voice + menu extraction.